LABOUR MIGRATION FROM BANGLADESH 2023

ACHIEVEMENTS AND CHALLENGES



RMMRU

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Introduction: 2023 is a momentous year for migration from Bangladesh as it is the country's national election year. This year, significant changes in policies have occurred, and migration-related issues have been included in the election manifestos. Like every year, this year also, RMMRU has published the annual migration report titled- "Labour Migration from Bangladesh 2023: Achievements and Challenges".

The report is divided into 7 sections. Section 1 presents statistics on migration and the flow of remittances in 2023. Section 2 focuses on the important events that took place that year. In section 3, the role of service providers has been evaluated. Section 4 highlights the major law and policy reform. Section 5 concentrates on changes in international laws, and section 6 highlights the role of civil society organisations with respect to the establishment of migrant rights. The report concludes with major conclusions and recommendations.

1. Labour Migration from Bangladesh 2023

1.1 Flow of Migrants

According to BMET information, in 2023, a total of 13,05,453 Bangladeshi workers migrated to different countries around the world for employment.[1] This is 13 percent higher in comparison to the previous year. A total of 11,35,873 Bangladeshi workers had migrated in 2022.[2] Analysing the migration data from 1976 to 2023, it is evident that this year Bangladesh has had the highest rate of increase in migration in the past 48 years.

From 2020 to 2021, Bangladesh's migration sector was at risk due to the COVID-19 pandemic. However, since 2022, the rate of labour migration from Bangladesh has increased again. This increase can be attributed to the fact that migrants who were unable to travel abroad during the COVID-19 pandemic have migrated in 2022 and 2023. the reopening of business establishments in labour- receiving countries after COVID-19 also contributed to such an increase. The increase of quota from 25 percent to 40 percent for Bangladeshi migrant workers in all Saudi institutions has also contributed to the rise in migration.[3] This trend of increased migration has been observed not only in Bangladesh but also in other South Asian countries since 2022. Migration from Nepal increased 300 times in 2022 compared to the

[1] BMET Statistics, https://old.bmet.gov.bd/BMET/viewStatReport.action?reportnumber=39
[2] BMET Statistics, https://old.bmet.gov.bd/BMET/viewStatReport.action?reportnumber=33
[3] https://archive.ph/4ANaC

previous year.

According to BMET statistics, from 1976 till 2023, a total of 16,075,487 Bangladeshi workers have migrated overseas for employment. However, this does not imply that currently, 16 million Bangladeshis work abroad.[4] Many of them have returned to Bangladesh after completing their work abroad. BMET does not maintain a database of Bangladeshi migrants who have returned home. However, in 2023, a total of 86,621 (83,719 male and 2,902 female) migrant workers returned with an Outpass. Figures from the Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics (BBS) show that in the years 2020 and 2021, a total of 4,66,666 Bangladeshi migrants permanently returned to the country.[5]

1.2 Female Migration

In 2023, a total of 76,519 female workers have migrated abroad for employment. In 2022, this number was 105,466. It is observed that compared to 2022, the flow of female migration decreased by 27.45 percent this year.[6] Of the total international migration, 5.86 percent were female workers this year. Last year, it was 9.3 percent. From 2015 to 2019, more than 100,000 annually migrated. After COVID-19, the number of female migrants is reducing. From 1991 to 2023, a total of 11,820,030 female workers have migrated abroad for employment.

1.3 Countries of Destination

Like last year, in 2023, the highest number of workers migrated to Saudi Arabia (4,97,674). This accounts for 38.12 percent of the total flow from Bangladesh. Despite being in the first position in terms of labour migration intake, the rate has decreased by 15.88 percent compared to the previous year. In 2022, around 54 percent of total migration took place in Saudi Arabia.

The second-highest migration is recorded in Malaysia, with 3,51,683 migrant workers. This accounts for 27 percent of Bangladesh's total flow. This is a significant increase from the previous year (22.53 percent). Following Malaysia, Oman ranks third, with 1,27,883 workers migrating to the country. This accounts for 9.80 percent of the total flow. Oman experienced a decrease of 6.2 percent in migration compared to the previous year when it held the second position. Next in line is the United Arab Emirates (UAE) (98,422 workers, 7.54 percent of the

[4] BMET website
[5] https://bangla.thedailystar.net/news/bangladesh/news-536731
[6] http://www.old.bmet.gov.bd/BMET/viewStatReport.action?reportnumber=8

total flow). The other countries include Qatar (56,148 workers, 4.30 percent) and Singapore (53,265 workers, 4.08 percent).[7]

Table 1: Figure Country- Wise Migration in 2023

No.	Country of Destination	Number of male workers employed	Percentage
1.	Saudi Arabia	4,97,674	38.12
2.	Malaysia	3,51,683	26.94
3.	Oman	1,27,883	9.80
4.	United Arab Emirates	98,422	7.54
5.	Qatar	56,148	4.30
6.	Singapore	53,265	4.08

Source: Created by RMMRU from data obtained from BMET

This year, among destination countries, the highest number of female migrant workers went to Saudi Arabia. In 2023, approximately 65.68 percent of total female workers (50,254) have migrated to this country. Jordan holds the second position (7,838 female workers, 10.24 percent), third Oman (6,547 female workers, 8.56 percent), fourth United Kingdom (5,256 female workers, 6.87 percent), fifth United Arab Emirates (UAE) (2,000 female workers, 2.61 percent) and sixth Kuwait (1,175 female workers, 1.54 percent).[8]

Table 2: Figure of Country-Wise Female Migration in 2023

No.	Country of Destination	Number of Female Migrant Workers	Percentage
1.	Saudi Arabia	50,254	65.68
2.	Jordan	7,838	10.24
3.	Oman	6,547	8.56
4.	United Kingdom	5,256	6.87
5.	United Arab Emirates	2,000	2.61
6.	Kuwait	1,175	1.54

[7] http://www.old.bmet.gov.bd/BMET/viewStatReport.action?reportnumber=11
[8] http://www.old.bmet.gov.bd/BMET/viewStatReport.action?reportnumber=38

Source: Created by RMMRU from data obtained from BMET

1.4 Source Area

Cumilla, Brahmanbaria, Chattogram, Noakhali, Chandpur, Tangail, Kishoreganj, Mymensingh, Narsingdi, and Dhaka are the major migrant prone areas in 2023. Like previous years, the largest outflow of migrants has been experienced in the Cumilla district (8.33 percent, 1,08,870 migrant workers). The second largest area of origin was Brahmanbaria (4.96 percent, 64,807 workers). Chattogram ranked third (4.91 percent, 64,202 migrant workers), while it ranked second in the previous year. Tangail ranked fourth at 4.14 percent, with 54,096 migrant workers who were in the sixth position previously. The rest of the districts include Chandpur (3.60 percent, 47,123 migrant workers), Kishoreganj (3.39 percent, 44,292 migrant workers), and Noakhali (3.38 percent, 44,135 migrant workers), respectively.

1.5 Skill Composition

BMET divides Bangladeshi migrant workers into four categories: professional, skilled, semi-skilled, and less-skilled. This year, 4.14 percent of total migrant workers are professionals, 24.77 percent are skilled, 21.01 percent are semi-skilled, and 50 percent belong to the less-skilled category. Compared to last year, this year, the rate of professionals, skilled workers, and semi-skilled workers has increased by 3.8 percent, 2.04 percent, and 17.36 percent, respectively. The percentage share of less-skilled workers has decreased by 23 percent.[9]

Table 3: Figure of Skilled Composition in the Year of 2021 and 2022

Skill Composition	2022	2021
Professional	0.34 percent	0.14 percent
Skilled	22.73 percent	21.33 percent
Semi-skilled	3.85 percent	3.28 percent
Unskilled	73.08 percent	75.24 percent

Source: Created by RMMRU from data obtained from BMET

1.6 Remittances

This year, USD 21.91 billion was received as remittance.[10] Compared to the previous year,

[9] Data collected from BMET
[10] https://www.bb.org.bd/en/index.php/econdata/wageremitance

remittance has increased by 2.88 percent in 2023. Last year, remittance was USD 21.28 billion. However, the amount of remittance received is much less than the number of people who migrated. This year, migration has increased by 13 percent, whereas remittances only increased by 2.88 percent.

From 2010 to 2023, Saudi Arabia was the top remittance-sending country in Bangladesh. The situation has changed this year. Remittance from Saudi Arabia amounted to USD 32.81 billion (14.97 percent). Compared to last year's remittances flow from Saudi Arabia, this year, it has decreased by approximately 3.9 percent.

The highest amount of remittances has been received from the United Arab Emirates, amounting to USD 36.72 billion. This accounts for 16.75 percent of the total flow to Bangladesh. Compared to last year's flow to UAE, it is 4.58 percent higher. It was in the third position last year.

This year, The United States is in the third position (USD 26.80 billion, 12.23 percent). Last year, it was in the second position. The other countries from where remittances have been received are the United Kingdom (USD 25.36 billion, 11.57 percent), Kuwait (USD 15.07 billion, 6.87 percent), and Italy (USD 13.37, 6.10 percent).[11] It appears that the increase in migration flow from a country does not necessarily result in an increase in remittance flow from that country. Although migration flow has increased to Saudi Arabia, the remittances from the United Arab Emirates have increased.

2. Important Incidents in the Migration Sector

2.1 Labour Market Reopened for Bangladeshis in Maldives

It is estimated that currently, there are 1,43,000 Bangladeshi migrants in the Maldives, which is the largest group of migrant workers in the country. Considering this, Maldives is a potential labour market for Bangladeshi migrant workers. Last year, RMMRU conducted a field study on labour migration in the Bangladesh-Maldives corridor. The study took the views of 120 Bangladeshi migrant workers residing in the Maldives and 250 returnee migrants from the country. At the same time, the research report was published after considering the opinions of various stakeholders and policymakers in the two countries at the public and private levels.[12] The research finds that, compared to the Gulf and other Arab States,

[11] https://www.bb.org.bd/en/index.php/econdata/wageremitance
[12] https://www.rmmru.org/newsite/wp-content/uploads/2024/01/Migration-Dynamics-of-Bangladesh-and-the-Maldives-Corridor.pdf

Bangladeshi migrant workers living in the Maldives are relatively better off in terms of pay and medical treatment. Although they are preferred by employers for their motivation and dedication, the Maldivian government imposed a ban on the entry of Bangladeshi migrant workers in September 2019. Along with government actions, RMMRU's multidimensional efforts have contributed to the reopening of Maldives visas for Bangladeshi workers on 17 December 2023[13].

2.2 Inclusion of Migration Issues in the Election Manifesto

Under the banner of BCSM, RMMRU and Warbe DF led a demand to the political parties to pledge commitment towards the migrants in their election manifestos. 48 Recommendations/Demands were placed by the organisations to the members of parliament belonging to different political parties. The Awami League's election manifesto adopted many of the recommendations of BCSM members.

This included the continuation of effective measures to provide legal assistance to migrant workers abroad, expanding trade-based training systems in view of international needs to increase the sending of skilled labour, and taking legal measures to ensure fair treatment of women workers abroad.

The election manifesto of the Jatiya Party also included some of the demands such as language skills development, a safe working environment for female migrants, allocation of a portion of the national budget for the welfare of migrants and their families, legal support cells in embassies to ensure the legal rights of migrants, appointment of interpreters and panel lawyers, etc.

2.3 Recovering the Blood Money as Compensation

As compensation for the death of two Bangladeshi migrant workers killed in Saudi Arabia, the highest amount of blood money, amounting to BDT 29 Crore, has been received.[14] The Bangladeshi embassy will hand over the money to the relatives of the deceased workers after identifying the heirs. Sagar Patwary traveled to Saudi Arabia for work in 2005 and was shot dead by an assailant at a petrol pump in Dammam city in 2006.[15] When the complaint filed by the Labour Welfare Wing was proved against the accused in 2021, the court sentenced him to

[13] https://www.somoynews.tv/news/2023-12-17/uXQvLLKM
[14] https://bangla.thedailystar.net/news/bangladesh/news-543901
[15] Ibid

death by beheading. Later, the father of the accused offered compensation to withdraw the death penalty in exchange for blood money. The compromise was settled for BDT 14 crore 88 lakh with the intervention of the embassy, and it was received in 2023.

In 2018, another Bangladeshi migrant worker, Mosammat Abiran Begum, was murdered by her employer in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia. In 2021, the court sentenced the main accused to death and sentenced the other accused to various terms of imprisonment and fines.[16] Although there was an appeal against the verdict, the death sentence was upheld. Later, based on a settlement with the family of the accused, the death sentence was waived this year in exchange for blood money of BDT 14 crore 23 lakh with the support of the Bangladesh Embassy.

2.4 Commencement of National Diaspora Day

Although the United Nations has declared December 18 as International Migrants' Day for all groups of migrants, the government of Bangladesh has declared December 30 as the National Migrants' Day for long-term international migrants. Based on the importance of observance, the day is listed as category B by the Cabinet Division, while on 18th December, the UN International Migrants Day, is listed as category C. Since 1996, the civil society has been celebrating International Migrants Day. Since 2007, the government has taken over the responsibility of observing the day. 18th December is listed as Category C. Category C has less entitlement than Category B.

2.5 Special Incentives from Banks to Encourage the Flow of Remittance

In 2022, the government increased incentives from 2% to 2.5%. In October 2023, the Association of Bankers Bangladesh (ABB) and Bangladesh Foreign Exchange Authorised Dealers Association (BAFEDA) announced a maximum incentive of 2.5% by commercial banks in addition to the 2.5% incentive offered by the government. [17]

2.6 Closure of Romania Consulate Office in Bangladesh

Romania opened a visa consulate office in Bangladesh in February 2023 at the BMET office in Dhaka. Romania wanted to issue 15,000 visas to migrant workers over the next 6 months.[18] Unfortunately, the consular office withdrew its operations from Bangladesh after a month in

[16] Ibid
[17] https://archive.ph/e9S5b
[18] https://www.prothomalo.com/bangladesh/bvsr9v7j1m

the face of unethical pressure from the influential parties.[19] The office has been transferred to the Romanian Embassy in New Delhi, India.[20] This is a huge loss for Bangladesh.

2.7 Regularisation of Irregular Workers

2.7.1 Opportunities for Regularisation of Irregular Migrants in Malaysia

The Malaysian government undertook the Workforce Recalibration (RTK 2.0) programme in January this year, which provided an opportunity to obtain regular visa status from irregular.[21] This opportunity was offered till 31st December 2023. More than 700,000 applications were received, including those from Bangladeshi workers.[22] Bangladesh High Commission in Kuala Lumpur issued passports to the irregular migrants after verifying their Bangladeshi citizenship. Passports were transferred through the Post Office, Passport Service Center of Bangladesh High Commission in KL, and CBL Money Transfer House.

2.7.2 Regularisation of Bangladeshi Workers in Greece

From January to 30th November 2023, the government of Greece implemented a regularization scheme.[23] The application was contingent on having a Bangladeshi passport with two years validity, proof of residence in Greece before 9 February 2022, and proof of work permit if regular. So far, more than 10,000 Bangladeshi migrants have registered, and 6,000 are awaiting residence permits.

2.8 Suspension of Visa

2.8.1 Visa Suspension for Bangladeshi Nationals in Oman

Bangladeshi nationals could go to Oman on tourist and visit visas and change their visa status to work visas. From October 2023, the Royal Oman Police suspended the system of visa status change as a measure to ensure labour market stability.[24] The country, however, has promised to lift the ban soon.

2.8.2 Bahrain Government Ceased Migration of Bangladeshi Workers

Bahrain has been one of the destination countries for Bangladeshi migrants., Since 2020, it

[19] https://www.bangladeshmonitor.com.bd/news-details/romania-has-closed-its-temporary-visa-consulate-office

[20] Ibid
[21] https://bangla.thedailystar.net/abroad/news-540951
[22] Ibid
[23] https://archive.is/U1aSp

[24] https://bangla.thedailystar.net/news/bangladesh/news-528706

has been decreasing, but this year, it has almost stopped.[25] The remittance flow from the country has also decreased.

2.9 Human Trafficking, Smuggling, and Migration

Every year, approximately 5000 people from Bangladesh attempt to reach developed countries through unsafe means.[26] But many of those are cheated and experience great financial and untimely returns. Recently, 140 people arrested in Libya have been sent back to the country. In 2022, a United Nations report on human trafficking revealed that Bangladesh's Dhaka, Khulna, and Sylhet divisions have the highest number of labour smuggling/trafficking cases.[27] Recently, the countries of the European Union have reached a consensus on tougher migration laws.

2.10 Formation of Trade Union Platform for Migrant Workers

In 2023, to protect the rights of migrant workers, 6 Garment Workers' Federation and 1 Domestic Workers Union of Women formed a Trade Union Platform for Migrant Workers. Its founding member organisations are Bangladesh Garments and Industrial Workers Federation, Bangladesh Mukta Garments Sramik Union Federation, Bangladesh Biplobi Garments Workers Federation, Sammilito Garments Sramik Federation, Ekota Garments Sramik Federation, Garment Sramik Sanghati Federation, and Jatiya Garhostyo Nari Sramik Union.[28] The co-founding organisations of this platform are Solidarity Centre Bangladesh, Bangladesh Centre for Workers Solidarity, Awaz Foundation, and Bangladeshi Obhibashi Mohila Sramik Association.

3. Service Providers

3.1 District Employment and Manpower Office (DEMO)

Currently, 42 District Manpower and Employment Offices (DEMO) and 4 Divisional Employment and Manpower Offices are functioning under BMET. These offices deliver services such as online registration, fingerprint service, and awareness-raising campaigns. Among those, the DEMOs of 7 districts (Chattogram, Cumilla, Rangpur, Pabna, Jashore, Sylhet, and Gopalganj) provide smart card services, and 11 other DEMOs offer pre-departure

[25] https://archive.ph/mQxDG
[26] https://www.bbc.com/bengali/news-60136296
[27] https://www.bbc.com/bengali/articles/cz4lz70d1l8o
[28] https://bangla.thedailystar.net/news/bangladesh/news-518311

orientation.[29] This year, the ministry has approved increasing the capacity of the workforce of 42 District Employment and Manpower Offices as well as decentralising all the services of BMET. Administrative approval for establishing new DEMOs in 22 districts has also been issued.

3.2 Technical Training Center (TTC)

Under BMET, a total of 110 training centres operate in the country. Among them, 104 are Technical Training Centres (TTCs), and 6 are Institutes of Marine Technology (IMTs) offering training in 55 trades suitable for employment.[30] In addition, the training centres have been set up in 40 upazilas, and approval has been granted for the establishment of TTCs in 50 more upazilas.

Currently, language courses are offered in 44 TTCs. These 44 TTCs offer courses in the Japanese language, 16 TTCs provide training in the English language, 32 TTCs in the Korean language, 3 TTCs in Chinese (Cantonese), and 1 TTC in Chinese (Mandarin) language. As an initiative to bring training under international accreditation, under the based accreditation body, the 'City & Guilds' diploma, 4 TTCs have included a Diploma course on Electronics and Electrical Engineering, Housekeeping Services, Food Preparation and Culinary Arts with a duration of 6 months each.[31] Training on the housekeeping trade is provided for a duration of 2 months in 39 TTCs. Furthermore, 3 TTCs offer heavy equipment operation (crane, road roller, forklift) courses, 17 TTCs offer Hospitality courses, and 95 TTCs provide training on driving. BMET also provides Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL) certificates through 44 vocational training centres to experienced workers returning from abroad, covering various trades.[32]

This year, in collaboration with the Saudi Arabian government, the company Takamol Bangladesh was established. The company is conducting a Skill Verification Programme (SVP). SVP tests are conducted in 6 TTCs on 12 professions. Bangladeshi workers who plan to migrate to Saudi Arabia can now obtain skill-specific certificates. This is important as Bangladesh has been working hard to increase the share of skilled migration from the country. The NTVQF/BNQF framework following BTEB/NSDA provides a certificate of skill.

[29] http://bmet.portal.gov.bd/site/page/53e682c1-3a63-4b6f-a69f-00fb5032208d/-
[30] https://archive.ph/Ckdxm
[31] Need reference
[32] Need reference

Although these training centres are established from the government's development budget, they often lack sufficient budget allocation from revenue accounts for the management of training operations. If the training programmes are managed jointly by the government and non-government organisations, it will further expand the scope, thereby creating more opportunities for employment by enhancing the quality of skills of the workforce.

3.3 Wage Earners' Welfare Board (WEWB)

In 2023, the WEWB disbursed BDT 39.60 million worth of financial assistance for the return and medical treatment of 457 injured and sick migrant workers. BDT 20.06 million was provided by the Board to 338 migrant workers in the previous year (2022). From 2010 to 2023, the Board has paid a total of BDT 181.50 million to 1,939 migrant workers.

A total of 4,574 dead bodies of migrant workers were brought back to the country in 2023, and the Board provided a total of BDT 160.09 million to the families for transportation and burial costs. In 2022, 3,904 dead bodies were returned to the country, and BDT 136.64 was provided for their transportation and burial costs. From 1993 to 2022, the Board provided BDT 1,667.56 million for the transportation and burial costs of 51,978 dead bodies. [33]

BDT 1481.79 million worth of financial support was provided by the board among family members of 5006 migrant workers in 2023. In 2022, it was BDT 1816.93 million against 6114 members of the migrant families. The cumulative figure in this head from 1996 to 2023 stands at BDT 1481.79 million to family members of 52339 families.[34]

In 2023, the board distributed BDT 874.47 million among 1316 migrant workers as compensation for deaths, regular arrears, and service benefits. In 2022, it was BDT 733.84 million against 1,142 migrant families. The cumulative figure from 1977 to 2023 stands at BDT 9123.31 million against 23,399 migrant families in this respect.[35]

In 2023, the Board disbursed scholarships worth BDT 86.83 million among 2,946 children of migrant workers.[36] Scholarships worth BDT 125.15 million were distributed among 6,138 children of migrant workers in 2022 by the board.[37] From 2012 till November 2022, the Board distributed BDT 481,94 million to 26,690 children of migrant workers for the same purpose.[38]

[33] https://archive.ph/5d0Mq
[34] https://archive.ph/7rOBr
[35] ibid
[36] ibid
[37] ibid
[38] ibid

In 2023, a total of 60,297 people have registered for Diaspora membership. Last year (2022), 46,160 people have registered. Together, 2,05,478 people of Bangladeshi origin have registered for Diaspora membership since June 2017.[39]

The Welfare Board has been providing disability benefits for disabled children of migrant households in 12 categories. In 2012, 862 disabled children of migrants were provided with BDT 10.34 million. From 2021 to 2023, a total of 1592 individuals have been provided with BDT 19.104 million.

3.4 Labour Wing

At present Bangladesh Embassies located in 27 countries have a total of 30 Labour Welfare Wings working to serve the migrant workers in the countries. The main responsibility of the Labour Welfare Wing is to protect the rights and security of the migrant workers. The WEWB provides legal assistance in handling cases in different courts, recovery of compensation, arrears and other benefits, bringing dead bodies, running safe homes for runaway/deserter women workers through these Labour Welfare Wings

3.5 Probashi Kallyan Bank (PKB)

In the fiscal year of 2023-2024, up to December 2023, Probashi Kallyan Bank has disbursed BDT 729.28 crores to 32,194 migrants as migration, reintegration, special reintegration loans and Bangabandhu Expatriate Family Loan. In the fiscal year 2023-2024, the total recovered amount was BDT 376.92 crores. In the previous fiscal year, 2022-2023, Probashi Kallyan Bank provided BDT 953.91 crore to 41,600 migrants as loans.[40]

During this fiscal year until December, BDT 669.16 crores was disbursed by the Bank among 30,011 aspirant migrants. Under the resettlement loan scheme, 1,004 individuals were provided with BDT 28.65 Crore.[41] Besides, BDT 4.14 crore was disbursed among 217 individuals as a women migration loan, and BDT 0.43 crore was distributed to 15 women migrants as a women's reintegration loan. From June to December 2023, 83 returnees received BDT 2.44 crore as a reintegration loan. Bangabandhu Immigrant's Large Family Loan of BDT 21.11 crore was distributed among 747 people, and Self-employment loans of BDT 3.35 crore were disbursed to 117 migrants.

[39] Ibid
[40] Information from Probashi Kallyan Bank
[41] Ibid

The total amount of BDT 3367.01 loan was disbursed among 1,67,335 migrants up to December 2023 from the financial year 2011-2012 to the financial year 2023-2024. In contrast, a total of BDT 1576.33 core has been recovered in the same period from the migrants and member of the families.

From Probashi Kallyan Bank, a maximum of BDT 5 million has been allocated for repatriation loans and Bangabandhu Expatriate Family loans. Up to BDT 3 million can be accessed without collateral. In cases where the amount exceeds BDT 5 million, the loan taker or the guarantor's immovable property will be mortgaged at the bank's discretion.

The repayment period for these loans is 10 years, with an interest rate of 9 percent. For Bangabandhu Immigrant's Large Family Loan , the interest rate for men is 9 percent, and for women, it is 7 percent.

Currently, the bank has 120 branches operational nationwide. There has been a plan to start the scheduled banking programme of Probashi Kallyan Bank in 2024. An agreement has been made with Sonali Bank, through which all customers of Probashi Kallyan Bank can pay their installment dues from all branches of Sonali Bank.[42]

3.6 BOESL

Between June 2023 and December 2023, BOESL sent a total of 18,294 migrant workers to different countries, including South Korea, Jordan, Hong Kong, Seychelles, Fiji, Mauritius, Russia, Japan, Kuwait, Croatia, and Malaysia. This represents 2 percent of all those who migrated this year. Among them, 6978 skilled migrants migrated to Jordan and 6,749 to South Korea through BOESL. The agency has sent 1,50,000 skilled, semi-skilled, and low-skilled migrant workers to 32 countries so far.[43]

3.7 Complaints

BMET accepts complaints directly from deceived migrant workers. Upto 2023, it has received 2380 complaints from affected migrants, resolved 865 cases, and recovered BDT 4,87,91,980 as compensation on behalf of affected migrants and members of their families. In 2022, 1240 complaints were lodged in BMET, and 339 cases were resolved. Through arbitration, BMET has been able to reequip BDT 1,60,18,700 as compensation for the aggrieved migrants.

[42] https://archive.ph/Hc13n
[43] Information from BOESL

Although until 2018, deceived migrants could file complaints both manually and online; currently, only manual complaints are accepted. If the system for online complaint submission could be reinstated, it would further enhance assistance for deceived migrants.

3.8 Recruiting Agency

In 2023, the number of licensed recruiting agencies in Bangladesh was 2153.[44] This year, 499 more agencies have obtained licenses. Among these, 693 agencies send women workers to Saudi Arabia.[45] BMET has suspended the license of 249 recruiting agencies after investigating various allegations and canceled the license of 128 agencies in 2023.[46]

This year, following a directive of the Ministry of Expatriates Welfare and Overseas Employment, BMET and RMMRU are jointly conducting two days of training on ethical recruitment for newly licensed recruiting agencies. Last year, 523 agencies in six batches received this training. Previous license holders are also receiving advanced training.

4. Changes in Migration Laws and Policies

4.1. Overseas Employment and Migrants (Amendment) Act, 2023

On 25th July 2023, The Overseas Employment and Migrant Act 2013 has been amended. Members of BCSM have played a significant role in negotiating the rights of migrants through fruitful advocacy and participation in meetings of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment Ministry. Notable points raised during the review included the inclusion of references to the International Convention on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of Their Families, 1990, and other relevant international labour and human rights instruments, retaining the original title of the law, and ensuring that the provisions of this law are not effective on human trafficking and other relevant laws. The proposed amendments to the amended law include retaining the concise title mentioned in section 1 and the complementary provisions mentioned in section 46, which were previously in force. Furthermore, the law includes provisions regarding sub-agents or representatives in Section 2(18) of the law, where their association is recognised, and their registration and appointment are included in Section 14 A – a demand that RMMRU,

[44] http://www.bmet.gov.bd
[45] http://www.old.bmet.gov.bd/BMET/resources/notice/2056.pdf
[46] http://www.old.bmet.gov.bd/BMET/raHomeAction

WARBE, and other BCSM members had been advocating for a long time. Additionally, notable changes included in the amended law are provisions for the reintegration and other welfare programmes for migrant workers and their families in Section 30, responsibilities of migrant workers in Section 30 A, penalties related to recruitment activities after the cancellation or revocation of licenses in Section 33, penalties for operating branch offices by agencies or sub-agents in Section 35, the consideration of offenses mentioned in Sections 31, 33, and 34 as actionable, bailable, and non-compoundable, and the provisions regarding offenses mentioned in Sections 32, 33A, and 35 as non-actionable, bailable, and compoundable.

4.2 Overseas Employment and Migrants (Registration and Conduct of Sub-agents) Rule

In accordance with the provisions of the Overseas Employment and Migrants (Amendment) Act, 2023, the Ministry of EWOE is preparing the Overseas Employment and Migrants (Registration and Conduct of sub-agents) Rule 2023. The Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment bestowed the responsibility of preparation of the draft to RMMRU. A draft has been submitted to the then-secretary of the ministry[47].

In clauses 3, 4, 5, and 6 of the draft legislation, application for registration, issuance of registration, reconsideration, and renewal of registration are discussed. In Schedule 1, details such as application fees, renewal fees, security, application fees for renewal, renewal of registration fees, penalties for late registration renewal, and duplicate registration fees are provided. In Schedule-2, four registration forms have been included. In clause 9, the selection of sub-agents or representatives by recruiting agencies has been mentioned, and in clause 10, the duties and conduct of sub-agents or representatives have been determined.

4.3 The National Diaspora Policy of Bangladesh 2023

The Ministry of EWOE has drafted a diaspora policy for Bangladeshi citizens residing abroad and for foreign nationals of Bangladeshi origin. According to the proposed policy, in line with the announcement of the Global Diaspora Conference held in Dublin in 2022, Bangladesh has reaffirmed its commitment to international pledges regarding the integration of non-resident

[47] https://www.rmmru.org/newsite/wp-content/uploads/2024/01/Proposed-draftRules-of-Sub Agent-by-RMMRU.pdf

Bangladeshis. As per the Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment Policy 2016, the term "diaspora" encompasses both non-resident Bangladeshi and Migrant workers.

The first article of this policy discusses the role of diaspora in Bangladesh's national development. It highlights the potential, challenges, coherence with national and international policy frameworks, and institutional management related to the national development of the Bangladeshi diaspora. The second paragraph outlines the main objectives and goals of the policy, which aims to establish arrangements for the multifaceted and multidirectional integration of the Bangladeshi diaspora.

The third paragraph outlines future government initiatives based on the core principles, objectives, and guiding principles of this policy. These initiatives include strengthening diaspora diplomacy and diplomatic capabilities, initiating diaspora registration, promoting Bangladesh's positive image through diaspora engagement in social and cultural activities, establishing a diaspora network for safe migration, encouraging investment in productive sectors, promoting trade in domestic goods and services, encouraging diaspora investment in the tourism industry, and encouraging remittance through legal channels.

5. Protection of Migrant Workers in the International Law

5.1 Stricter Migration Regime in France

In the recently passed Bill, there is an indication of stricter migration policies and further toughening of immigration laws in France. In the controversial bill, it has been suggested that the process of deciding asylum applications be expedited.[48] Additionally, it has been suggested that the time limit for appeals be reduced in case of application rejection. There is a recommendation to make the family reunion visa process complicated, which will make migration for individuals who have family members in France difficult. There is also a possibility of making visa applications for medical treatment in France more difficult. A possible change is likely to occur regarding sending back those under 13 years of age.

5.2 New Law to Control Irregular Migration in the United Kingdom

To control the influx of irregular migrants using small boats to the United Kingdom, the

[48] https://www.prothomalo.com/world/europe/c7ez6mkdtq

country has passed a new law.[49] The law reform has created provisions that deny asylum to anyone who enters by irregular means, even if someone's life is at risk. If someone is caught entering irregularly, they could be sent to a third country under this law, and there is a provision to never allow entry into the UK for someone caught arriving irregularly once. While the law has faced widespread criticism, the government claims that in 2022, around 45,000 people tried to enter the UK through irregular paths. The cost of accommodating this large number of asylum seekers is estimated to be around USD 4 billion. Although the UK government wanted to transfer irregular immigrants to countries like Rwanda in Africa, the legal complexities have halted this process. While the new law has been approved, it is not being implemented immediately.

5.3 Stricter Laws on Migration by the European Union

The countries of the European Union are moving towards consensus on enforcement of laws aimed at controlling irregular migrants. Consequently, it is expected that EU migration laws will become even stricter. Providing shelter to irregular migrants in Europe, expedited verification and selection processes, rapid repatriation of individuals whose asylum applications are rejected, and the establishment of detention at borders are some major issues that have been focused on here. Under this process, several asylum seekers will be relocated to various countries within the European Union. If any asylum seeker is denied shelter by a certain country, they are expected to contribute financially or through infrastructure.

5.4 Positive Changes in Migration Law in Germany

The government of Germany has proposed amendments to the Citizenship law aimed at solving the skilled worker crisis and making citizenship more attractive for migrants. As a result of these amendments, obtaining citizenship may become easier for migrants.[50] One major change in the draft law is the reduction of the residency requirement for citizenship applications from eight years to five years. This means that if someone resides regularly in Germany for five years, they can apply for citizenship. Individuals with skills, voluntary work, language proficiency, and financial independence for themselves and their families may be granted approval after three years under special consideration.

6. Civil Society Initiatives

[49] https://www.dhakapost.com/international/210002
[50] https://www.prothomalo.com/world/europe/441eg80h6e

Bangladesh Civil Society for Migrants (BCSM)

This year, BCSM, the association of civil society organisations, has campaigned for meaningful cooperation of the rights of migrants in different parties' election manifestos. Through the Parliamentarians' Caucus on Migration and Development, BCSM advocated for the allocation of the budget for the rights and welfare in the manifesto of the political parties for the 12th national parliamentary election.

RMMRU This year, RMMRU, in collaboration with the Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment and BMET, provided training to 523 agencies' proprietors/managers/partners of recruiting agencies in six batches. Through a directive of the Ministry of Expatriates' Welfare and Overseas Employment, this training course is being considered as a foundation course. It is mandatory for those who have applied for new licenses.

RMMRU has organised the "Obhibashon o Shonar Manush Shommilon 2023" to acknowledge the contributions of migrants and to provide recognition to them as entrepreneurs, successful remittance user families, and service-providing organisations. Additionally, as part of the reintegration, support worth BDT 10,80000 was provided to 12 returnee migrants.

WARBE Development Foundation This year, research was conducted to determine the required budget allocation for migrants in the upcoming fiscal year's national budget. The findings of the research were presented by the Parliamentarian's Caucus on Migration and Development members in the National Parliament.

BRAC BRAC has reached 150,935 individuals through awareness-raising workshops, school programmes, and video shows, while 5,689 individuals have been provided reintegration services. Additionally, 1689 migrants have received financial management training, and 1159 have been provided with psychosocial counseling.

The Bangladesh Obhibashi Mohila Sramik Association (BOMSA) This year, alongside other services, BOMSA has prepared a sample contract for domestic workers in accordance with the guidelines for the safety and welfare of domestic workers.

BASTOB BASTOB has supported 45 women workers by providing financial literacy and entrepreneurship training.

BNSK Through awareness-raising programmes such as workshops, school programmes, and video shows, 1607 individuals were made aware of safe migration, while 1132 were provided reintegration support. Alongside this effort, 772 individuals were provided with emergency services and other forms of assistance.

Manusher Jonno Foundation (MJF) In 2023, MJF provided reintegration services to 2000 returnees. It also facilitated loans for initiating business ventures to 200 individuals.

YPSA 70 individuals received counseling services in districts Chattogram, Cox's Bazar, Feni, and Chandpur. 100 individuals were provided with referral services and other assistance.

Recommendations:

- Declare 2025 to 2035 the Decade of Migration.
- Instead of observing two separate days for labour migration and the diaspora, designate December 18 as the Day for all migrants, as declared by the United Nations. Reclassify the observance of International Migrants Day from 'C' to 'B'.
- Budget allocation should be kept for the specific commitments made in favour of the migrants in the manifestos of the political parties.
- Bring back the online complaint mechanism, which was in operation for a long period.
- International labour migration should be recognised as a pathway for climate adaptation for vulnerable families. In this regard, special loan projects should be initiated from various climate funds.
- To encourage the flow of remittances through formal channels, the trust of the migrants towards the banking channel has to be regained. Opportunities for investment for short-term migrants have to be increased. Migrants and their families should be informed about the opportunities through mass media and social media.